

The anchor tenant returns

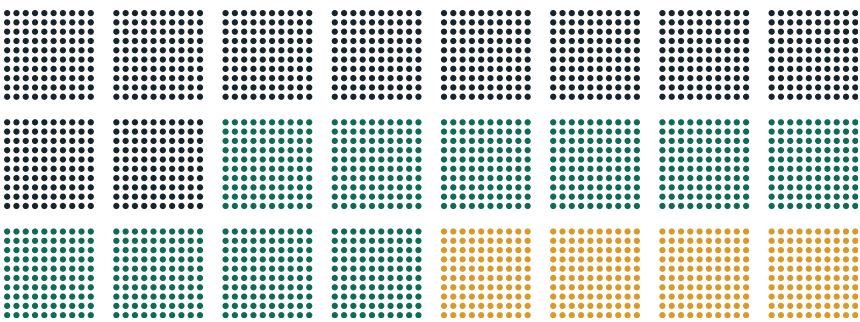
Signal Meta signed 20-year contracts for 3,760 MW of nuclear output from four plants already running in Illinois, Ohio and Pennsylvania. About 12% of that is new output. The rest was already on the grid.

Read Long power contracts are old. New: a tech company reserving city-sized supply that already exists, inside a market that is short, where households share the cost of the shortage.

Researched October 1, 2026. Tags in the left margin: Fact is sourced, Read is our inference, Est is computed.

How big is 3,760 MW?

Each dot is 1,160 homes. Each block of 100 dots is one tenth of Chicago's households. Twenty-four blocks is roughly the electricity Meta reserved.

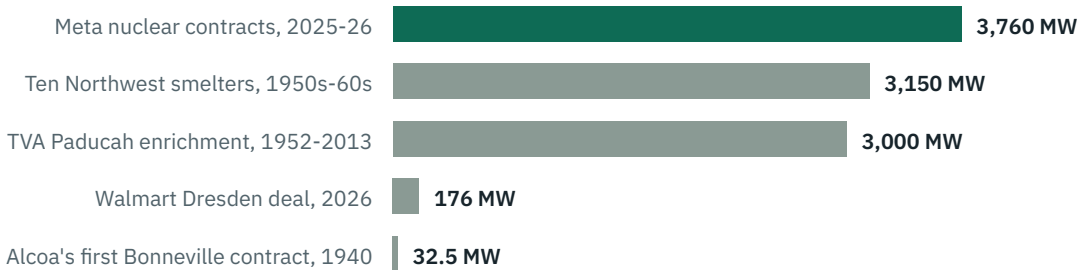


● Chicago, once ● Chicago, twice ● and four tenths more

2.4

times every household in Chicago, powered for a year. Estimate: 3,760 MW at 90% of hours, 10,791 kWh per home, 1.16 million Chicago households. Math on page 3.

Against the last industry that anchored a grid



"In 1940 Alcoa signed for Bonneville dam power. Ten Northwest smelters ran on it for sixty years, then sold the power back and left. The dams stayed. The buyers didn't."

Northwest Power and Conservation Council history.

How 2.4 Chicagos was computed

3,760 MW Meta contracted: 1,121 + 30 + 2,176 + 433	x 90% hours running, hours in a year	= 29.6 bn kWh a year	/ 10,791 kWh average US home, EIA 2022	= 2.75 M homes / 1,160,205 Chicago households, Census 2020-24	= 2.4 Chicagos estimate
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Who else is doing this

Buyer	What they bought	Size	Term	New to the grid	The read
Meta	Clinton (IL) plus three Vistra plants (OH, PA)	3,760 MW	20 yr	12%	Largest block. Mostly existing output
Amazon	Susquehanna (PA), moved to a grid contract after regulators rejected the on-site version	1,920 MW	to 2042	0%	\$18 billion for power that already flowed
Amazon	Calvert Cliffs (MD), signed Sep 30	690 MW	20 yr	28%	Filed a campus, withdrew it, kept the power. Sequence below
Microsoft	Crane, the former Three Mile Island unit, restart	835 MW	20 yr	100%	The one restart a buyer clearly caused
Google	Duane Arnold (IA) restart, plus uprates at two Georgia plants	615 + 96 MW	25 yr	100%	Longest term in the book
Data4	Output from EDF, the French state utility that runs the national nuclear fleet	40 MW	12 yr	0%	How it looks where the state owns the plants
Walmart	Dresden (IL), for a perishable distribution center opening 2029	176 MW	2 x 15 yr	17%	First retailer. The template for any big automated site

Across the signed book: 8,006 MW, 27% new. The two biggest blocks are 100% existing output. No deal has disclosed a price.

What 24/7 power looks like if you're not a hyperscaler

Utility bill	Month to month. Price taker. No reserved capacity. Where most companies still are.
Clean-energy contract	10 to 15 years. A price hedge and a sustainability claim. No reliability benefit, no electrons to your site. Walmart's 2024 Texas solar deal.
Site-tied firm supply	15 to 25 years. Capacity plus energy, tied to a named plant. Minimum bills, collateral, curtailment clauses. Walmart's 2026 nuclear deal. Where the line forms now.

25 MW

where utility minimum-bill rules start in Ohio and Virginia

85%

of reserved power billed, used or not, for 12 to 14 years

4 years

typical ramp before the full minimum applies

30 minutes

to cut off on command in Texas, the price of a fast hookup

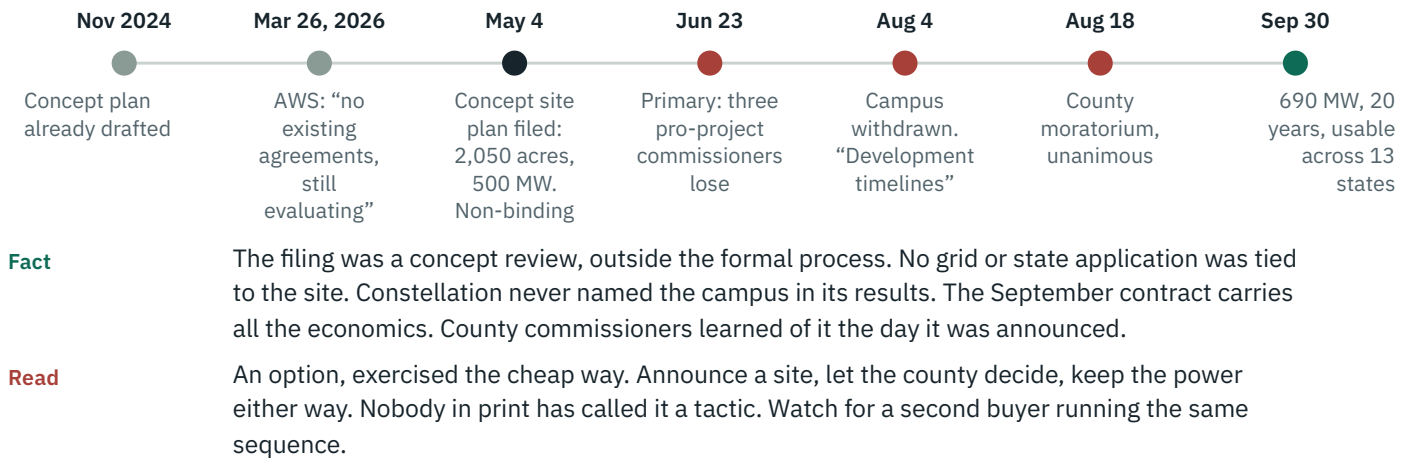
An automated warehouse, a cold-chain hub, a battery plant and a fab all cross 25 MW. The utility prices the power line before the automation plan does.

What's not being said

- The price. It is the only number in these deals that no party has published.
- Whether the plants would have run anyway. Vistra says the deal gives it "the certainty needed to invest." Nobody can prove the counterfactual.
- The 20-year term is the least informative number. Anchors renegotiate at the boundaries. Watch years 5 to 10.

The site was the option

Amazon at Calvert Cliffs, concept plan to power contract. The power flows into PJM, the grid operator for 13 states and Washington DC, so a Maryland contract serves Amazon anywhere in that footprint.



The last time an industry anchored a grid

Fact Alcoa signed for 32.5 average MW of Bonneville dam power in 1940. By the 1950s ten smelters drew 3,150 average MW and made 40% of US aluminum. When prices spiked in 2000-01, Kaiser made about \$130 million reselling its contract power instead of making metal. Industrial load fell 90% by 2006. The last smelter closed in 2023.

Read Anchors renegotiate at every contract boundary and leave when the spread flips. Bonneville's other customers absorbed the power. In today's private markets nobody absorbs it automatically, which is why the minimum-bill rules exist.

Who gains, who carries

Gains

Meta: 20 years of dedicated supply, and an exemption from curtailment.

Plant owners: revenue certainty to relicense and uprate.

Host towns: plants stay open, jobs and taxes continue.

Carries

Households in the 13-state grid: data centers are 38.2% of 2028/29 capacity charges, \$6.3 billion.

Virginia homes: \$13.60 a month across 2026-27.

The caveat

National bill studies through 2024 find small or no effect. Each one says slack supply kept it small.

PJM no longer has slack.

For an executive

- Which of our sites cross 25 MW in the next five years?
- If automation ramps two years late, what do we owe on power reserved and unused?
- When we buy a facility, does its power contract transfer with it?

What to watch

- Nov 3, 2026** 34 local data-center ballot measures. The four decided earlier this year all passed restrictions
- Nov 16, 2026** PJM's co-location rules and all six grid operators' answers to FERC
- Dec 2, 2026** PJM backstop auction, a second price tier up to \$555 per MW-day
- Next campus** Does another buyer file a site, secure the power, and drop the site?

Researched by NodeJ Deep Research. Every figure traces to a companion report with a source link on each number. For the full report, or a brief on a signal in your industry: julian@nodej.ai